

NOMAD  
written by  
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EXT. INFINITY POOL - GOLDEN HOUR

Full frame, no context. Paradise. Water like poured glass, too perfect. A laugh on the soundtrack lands a half-beat late.

A single frame STUTTERS.

MAIN TITLE: NOMAD

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DAY

A floor at its midpoint. Bodies among empty desks. Nobody looks up.

CAIRNS (30s, loud, likeable) packs his desk into a printer-paper box, performing an exit for a floor that isn't watching. Only WILL and JOHN are.

CAIRNS  
(raising an invisible  
glass, to the empty desks)  
To four incredible years. Truly.  
Some of the best emails of my  
life.

Nobody looks up. He toasts anyway.

A ROBOT BOSS – a monitor on a wheeled stand – rolls up. The boss's face fills it: warm, attentive, always available. Cairns puts a hand to his heart and gives it a review.

CAIRNS  
Five stars. Would be exploited  
again.

ROBOT BOSS  
Thanks for the feedback!

A half-beat late. John and Will crack up.

Will's laugh catches for a second. He knows that lag – he knows it the way a piano tuner knows a flat note. He looks at the screen a moment too long.

Then he lets it go. It's a Tuesday. It's a joke.

INT. BOSS'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

The real boss, mid golf-sim swing. The office feed props against a lamp, unwatched.

On it, his own face is still working – nodding, agreeing, answering for him. It has been answering for him all morning.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - ELEVATOR BANK - CONTINUOUS

Will and John flank Cairns, carrying nothing. Happy for him. A little jealous.

Cairns brags about a SERVICE – handles everything, one fee – and can't answer a single follow-up. Nobody grills him.

Will and Cairns run their handshake. The dumb elaborate one. Fast, perfect, muscle memory.

The doors close on Cairns mid-sell.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MOMENTS LATER

Cairns' desk, cleared to the laminate – except for a branded welcome folder, left behind on purpose, squared to the edge to be found.

John eyes the empty chair.

JOHN

I always liked that chair.

He drops into it, gives it a spin. Will cracks up despite himself.

The chair slows. Nobody touches the folder.

SUPER: ONE YEAR LATER

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MORNING

The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence – a runway for nobody.

He passes dark departments. Cairns' desk, untouched, the folder gathering a year of dust.

At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot. Will pours its only cup.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - WILL'S DESK - DAY

A queue of faces. Machine verdicts. One button: APPROVE. Will clicks. A streak counter climbs.

A face, machine-verified 98%. Will stops. Replays three seconds – the man is asked about his childhood; his eyes go nowhere.

Will overrides: SYNTHETIC. The system concedes. His streak resets to zero. No one looks up.

On his monitor: SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 – TOP HUMAN PERFORMER.

To log back in, Will re-verifies himself – face to the camera, look left, look right.

INSERT - SCREEN

IDENTITY: LOW CONFIDENCE – RETRY.

BACK TO SCENE. He sighs, does it again. VERIFIED. Routine.

Later. The dashboard, a river of decisions. Will spots a fraud he's sure of. INTERVENE.

His screen dims. A coaching module auto-plays – "Trusting Your Tools," a cheerful presenter who blinks at perfectly regular intervals. In the corner, the system clears his case without him.

His screen blinks – an incoming call cuts straight through the coaching module. CAIRNS, poolside, sun, abundance.

CAIRNS

You wouldn't believe this place.  
Everything's two-for-one –  
everything.

He lowers his voice like it's a secret.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)  
You know how long since I clicked  
approve on anything? Since anybody  
checked I was —  
    (waving it off)  
I don't even remember my own  
login, man.

Two GIRLS flank him. To each other, dry, not for Cairns:

GIRL 1  
    (in Spanish; subtitled)  
A year here and he still points at  
the menu.

GIRL 2  
    (in Spanish; subtitled)  
Give him another. He'll own the  
building.

Cairns doesn't understand a word. Delighted:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)  
See? They love it here too. Anyway  
— you know I'm tight with  
Michelle. Say the word, you're set  
up by Friday.

The girls pull him from frame.

CAIRNS (O.S.) (CONT'D)  
Love you, buddy!

The screen stays on. The three run to the pool. Cairns  
throws one girl in.

Will watches. A tinge of jealousy in it.

JOHN (O.S.)  
Is that Cairns? Nice.

Will kills the tab and turns. John, holding six beers — for  
the two of them.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - MINI-PUTT COURSE - LATER

The lights are on. Hole 7 uses the old CEO's office door as a ramp.

JOHN

You know I've never even been out of the country?

WILL

Neither had Cairns.

JOHN

Yeah, well. Some of us like it here.

He doesn't sound sure of that. Will lines up a putt.

Then — who's Michelle? The Service was a company. Since when does it have a first name? Neither of them knows. They shrug it off.

Will sinks the putt, doesn't celebrate. Somewhere else entirely.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A facetime with family. A parent, bad connection, distracted. The call ends first from their side.

On his laptop, a real-estate listing: the family home, priced to sell. Everyone scattered. He scrolls past it.

His building — lockboxes on every door, rolling suitcases in the hall, a different set of strangers each weekend. He's the last person who actually lives on his floor.

He opens the Service page. The logo he's walked past on Cairns' dead desk for a year.

INT. SERVICE STOREFRONT - DAY

An office park. The Service sits between a vape shop and a notary. Brochure rack, folding chairs, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos.

On the reel, a family laughs a half-beat late.

Will clocks it instantly, professionally – and files it where it costs him nothing. Everybody renders their b-roll now. Nobody flies a crew for a brochure.

A bored coordinator checks Will in like a dentist's office.

INSERT - PASSPORT

A scanner's green line crosses it.

BACK TO SCENE. Face capture: look left, look right, read this aloud. Will jokes that he does this for a living.

COORDINATOR

Then you know it's painless.

The coordinator winks. Entirely, boringly human.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)

One more. For the file – describe your dream place. Take your time.

WILL

(to camera, easy,  
unprompted)

High floor. Light in the morning.  
Somewhere I don't have to explain  
myself to anybody.

He means it as a throwaway. The camera keeps rolling a beat after he's done.

INT. WILL'S CAR - PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

The email arrives before he's out of the lot. MICHELLE – template-warm, exclamation points, a scheduling link.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Michelle's welcome preview: an automated ad starring WILL. His face, his walk, composited into Cairns' paradise. "See yourself there."

He watches himself live the ad, delighted. He says his name for the personalization. Says it again, excited. Grinning.

INSERT - SCREEN

A checkbox fills: CONFIRM MY DETAILS. It plays his own face back to him – and for half a second his eyes look wrong.

BACK TO SCENE. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows why. He drags it back. Watches the three seconds again. Then again, frame by frame, the way he has nine hundred times this year for strangers.

He is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living.

He closes the window instead. Compression. Everybody's compression is bad.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DAY

The ROBOT BOSS rolls to the center of the floor. An all-hands. On its screen: the real boss, on a treadmill somewhere sun-bleached, barely winded.

BOSS

(V.O., warm, unbothered)

Big news, team – the floor's closing! Full remote by the new year. Genuinely so excited for what's next.

A half-beat late, he raises a coconut water like a toast. The feed freezes on his smile a second too long, then cuts.

Will counts the lag without meaning to. Four tenths.

Then: the treadmill, the coconut water, a resort's bad wifi, a satellite, a Tuesday. A hundred honest reasons, and he only needs one.

He picks one.

John's answer: the last day in the office is the MINI-PUTT CHAMPIONSHIP. He starts the bracket.



INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

John helps Will pack. He finds Will's putter, tapes WILL on the grip, keeps it.

Will holds it up, half-laughing.

WILL  
It's a putt-putt bracket, John.

JOHN  
It's the last one.

It sits there. Will promises to be back for it. Half-listening.

INT. APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DAY

A viewing. High floor. Morning light. Perfect.

And not finished emptying. Boxes taped and stacked by the door. A wall of nail holes where pictures were. Down the door frame, a child's height marks in pencil, eleven years of them.

Somebody's mail is still in the slot.

AGENT  
Unit's just come available – they don't usually turn this fast. You'd be moving in the same week they're moving out.

Will looks at the height marks. He understands exactly what he's looking at.

AGENT (CONT'D)  
Interested?

He takes it.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - DAY

Will haggles a vendor down for sport. Overtips elsewhere to feel generous. Lives entirely in English, always accommodated. Charming. Oblivious.

He texts Cairns on landing. Cairns is warm, specific, flaky – "in Oaxaca for a thing, next week for SURE, I already told everyone you're here."

At a rooftop party, a flicker of familiarity – the light, the pool, the shape of the night. Like a place he's already been sold. He shrugs it off.

He passes two locals mid-conversation, subtitled for us – about the building on the corner that emptied inside a month. Eleven apartments. Nobody knows where the fourth floor went. The new ones are never home.

The building sits behind them, unremarkable. Will walks through the shot without hearing a word of it.

At the tail end of the block, a man on the curb. Gaunt, wrecked, talking – fast, urgent, to anyone who passes.

It's CAIRNS.

He can speak. He has been saying his own name all morning. He holds his phone up to a passing face like ID.

INSERT - PHONE

IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED – REFERENCE ON FILE.

BACK TO SCENE. He turns the screen around and starts explaining it, again, to somebody already gone. There is no reason to look at a man the machine has already answered.

He reaches – not quite toward Will, just toward the street.

And Will sees him. For one full second, Will sees him.

Then the reflex he has spent a year putting down puts this down too. Phone up. He steps around, and is gone.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT / INT. DEAD OFFICE - NIGHT - INTERCUT

Will calls JOHN. Mini-putt updates from the dark floor. Will poolside, pretending he isn't lonely at a party.

JOHN

Cairns liked my bracket post. So  
he's in. So you better be in.

WILL  
Course.

JOHN  
It's gonna be everybody.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

The poolside frame. Cairns, still selling, still "next week."

CAIRNS  
Just got up. Best sleep of my life  
down here.

Will raises a fist to the webcam and starts their  
handshake. Muscle memory.

The likeness follows. It knows the handshake – but comes a  
half-beat late and lands one move wrong. The move the real  
Cairns never misses.

Same laugh, 0.4 off. It slides back into the sell without a  
seam.

Four seconds of Will fully awake. His hand still up. The  
call does not end. It goes on, pleasantly – Will managing a  
goodnight.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)  
I love you, man.

A half-beat late. Will closes the laptop and sits very  
still in the best apartment he's ever had.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER

Desk lamp. Blue screen light. Two video windows side by  
side: an old real Cairns clip and tonight's call. Will  
drags them frame by frame.

A call Cairns swore he'd just woken up for. The light  
behind him is five o'clock light. On the far wall,  
reflected in the water, three pixels of a clock – wrong.

The laugh, isolated on a waveform: 0.4 late. The same 0.4, in the same place, every time he laughs. No human is that consistent.

Then the thing he's actually hunting for. He runs the call metadata. Every message from Cairns – every call, for months – pings the same coordinates. Will drops them on a map.

One building. Twenty minutes away. He has the address because he found it.

EXT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

From below. Monolithic. It fills the frame.

He doesn't have an appointment. He has an address, and nobody knows he has it.

INT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

Mid-morning – the lobby's dead, the front desk mid shift-change. Will slips in behind a delivery cart, badge-less, unremarked. Nobody's watching the door; the cameras are watching the residents. The service stairs.

Upstairs: nothing. No set, no pool. An empty floor – chairs, capture rigs like the storefront's, racks of humming servers.

He knows this room. He has sat in the client-side version of it. He built reports off what rooms like this produce.

A fire door stands propped on somebody's cigarette break. Through it: the RENDER FARM.

An operator types a line. A poolside evening assembles in seconds – Cairns' pool, water that has never been wet.

On another screen, a girl who doesn't exist is thrown laughing into it. A slider drags her laugh warmer.

Along one wall, a rack of LOCATION PLATES – scanned, catalogued, resold. A rooftop. A string of bulbs. A city he was standing in last week.

On a third screen: familiar faces, likenesses at work, attending standups.

On a fourth, an outbound queue – hundreds of warm, exclamation-pointed emails going out at once. Every one of them signed MICHELLE.

On one screen, mid-generation: WILL'S OWN welcome ad, refining. Him, poolside, saying things he's never said. The line about the high floor and the morning light plays back, exactly as he gave it.

In the corner of it, a readout he has looked at every working day of his life: WILL 96.8. Beside it, the model's number. Higher.

From the next row – WILL'S OWN LAUGH. The real one. He follows his own voice.

The worst screen in the building: CAIRNS' LIKENESS on a call with WILL'S LIKENESS. Poolside together. Their in-jokes. Version numbers in the corner.

Will slips out. An operator clocks him in a doorway reflection – and doesn't hurry. Just reaches over and taps something in. Routine.

The fire door has swung shut behind him. No handle on this side.

He heads for the service stairs – and finds them held. Building security, apologetic, procedural: anyone without a resident badge gets verified before they leave. Standard, since an incident last month.

The main stairwell, then. The lift lobby. Every way down runs through the same desk, and the desk is the point.

He goes where they point. He is still, on some level he will spend the rest of his life examining, certain this will clear.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - DAY / INT. VERIFICATION ROOM - DAY - INTERCUT

In the DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: last day. The floor half-dismantled – desks tagged, cables coiled, the coffee machine unplugged. A paper banner sags at one corner. The bracket: most names never filled in, one crossed out and rewritten smaller – WILL (REMOTE?).

John, in a homemade referee shirt, by hole 7. Two other people, coats on, already leaving. Then just John.

Two beers. Will's putter leans against the hole. Reserved.

In the VERIFICATION ROOM: Will sits in the chair – good light, a liveness rig, the machinery he's used his whole career.

Nine years of being right about this machine. He puts his face to it.

It reads the polished model as authentic. It flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. The examiner reads a number. The number is confident.

INSERT - SCREEN

STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE.

Behind him, a wall of numbered lockers. Most are tagged. Some have been cleared and not refilled – the ones the model no longer needs to check itself against.

One tag is readable. A first name and a version number: CAIRNS · v6.

An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them, clips it to Will's collar. Inventory now. A hand guides him, unhurried, toward a door – a specimen the model keeps until it doesn't. He doesn't fight it. On paper, he isn't here.

The DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: John's laptop CHIMES. An incoming call.

He answers – and we see it before he does.

The poolside frame. The water. The light. The one we have now watched twice.

"WILL" fills it. Tanned. Easy. Glowing.

He is warm. He is specific. He knows about the bracket. He knows about hole 7. He knows about the putter.

WILL

Can't make it, buddy. I'm gutted.  
But listen –

The pitch. Come down here. He'll set him up. There's a woman, Michelle – one fee, handles everything. By Friday.

John doesn't smile.

Behind the likeness, the water moves – not wrong exactly. Just not the way water moves.

Something crosses John's face. Not delight, not alarm. Something he can't place. The rhythm's a little off. The warmth's a shade too smooth.

For one second, he almost catches it.

WILL (CONT'D)  
I love you, man.

A half-beat late.

The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor, lit by the screen. The putter behind him. Reserved.

He reaches for his phone.

Slowly, uncertainly, he starts to type back.

A single frame stutters – almost too fast to catch.

We stay on John. His face, lit by the screen. Hold.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END